# Path-Coloring Algorithms for Plane Graphs

Aven Bross
Department of Computer Science
University of Alaska
Fairbanks, AK 99775-6670
dabross@alaska.edu

Glenn G. Chappell
Department of Computer Science
University of Alaska
Fairbanks, AK 99775-6670
chappellg@member.ams.org

Chris Hartman
Department of Computer Science
University of Alaska
Fairbanks, AK 99775-6670
cmhartman@alaska.edu

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**Abstract**

A path coloring of a graph $G$ is a vertex coloring of $G$ such that each color class induces a disjoint union of paths. We present two efficient, linear-time algorithms to construct a path coloring of a plane graph.

The first algorithm, based on a proof of Poh, is given a plane graph, and produces a path coloring of the given graph using three colors.

The second algorithm, based on similar proofs by Hartman and Škrekovski, performs a list-coloring generalization of the above. The algorithm is given a plane graph and an assignment of lists of three colors to each vertex, and it it produces a path coloring of the given graph in which each vertex receives a color from its list.

Implementations are available for all algorithms that are described.

# 1 Introduction

All graphs will be finite and simple. See West [12] for graph theoretic terms.

A graph is *planar* if it may be drawn in the plane without edge crossings, and such a drawing is called an *embedding*. A *plane graph* is a planar graph with a fixed embedding.

A *path coloring* is a (vertex) coloring where each color class induces a disjoint union of paths. A graph $G$ is *path $k$-colorable* if $G$ admits a path $k$-coloring (a path coloring using at most $k$ colors). A *list assignment* $L$ of a graph $G$ maps each $v \in V(G)$ to a finite set of colors $L(v)$. An *$L$-list-coloring* is a coloring $c$ such that $c(v) \in L(v)$ for each $v \in V(G)$. A graph is *path $k$-choosable* if it admits a path $L$-list-coloring for every list assignment $L$ with at least $k$ colors in each list, i.e. $|L(v)| \geq k$ for each $v \in V(G)$.

Broere & Mynhardt conjectured [2, Conj. 16] that every planar graph is path 3-colorable. This was proven independently by Poh [9, Thm. 2] and Goddard [6, Thm. 1].

**Theorem 1.1** (Poh 1990, Goddard 1991)**.** *If $G$ is a planar graph, then $G$ is path 3-colorable.* □

It is easily shown that the "3" in Theorem 1.1 is best possible. In particular, Chartrand & Kronk [5, Section 3] gave an example of a planar graph whose vertex set cannot be partitioned into two subsets, each inducing a forest.

Hartman [7, Thm. 4.1] proved a list-coloring generalization of Theorem 1.1 (see also Chappell & Hartman [4, Thm. 2.1]). Essentially the same coloring technique was used by Škrekovski [11, Thm. 2.2b] to prove a result slightly weaker than Theorem 1.2.

**Theorem 1.2** (Hartman 1997)**.** *If $G$ is a planar graph, then $G$ is path 3-choosable.* □

We discuss two path coloring algorithms based on proofs of the above theorems.

In Section 2 we outline our graph representations and the basis for our computations of time complexity.

Section 3 covers an algorithm based on Poh's proof of Theorem 1.1. The algorithm is given a plane graph; it produces a path coloring of the given graph using three colors.

Section 4 covers an algorithm based on Hartman's proof of Theorem 1.2, along with the proof of Škrekovski mentioned above. The algorithm is given a plane graph and an assignment of a list of three colors to each vertex; it produces a path coloring of the given graph in which each vertex receives a color from its list.

Section 5 provides performance results for our implementations of each algorithm [3]. The section also discusses how each algorithm may be modified to benefit from parallelism.

# 2 Graph Representations and Time Complexity

A *face* of a plane graph is a subgraph that, as drawn in the embedding, forms the border of a region of the plain that contains no point of the embedding. A plane graph is *triangulated* if each face is a 3-cycle, and *weakly triangulated* if it is connected and each interior (bounded) face is a 3-cycle.

A *rotation scheme* for a graph is a circular ordering of the incident edges around each vertex. An embedding induces a rotation scheme by the clockwise (or counter-clockwise) order in which edges appear around each vertex. The induced rotation scheme describes all of the combinatorial properties of an embedding. For example, the faces of the embedding correspond to the closed walks induced by the rotation scheme: the walks generated by

following an edge $uv$ from $u$ to $v$, then following the edge subsequent to $uv$ in the rotation scheme around $v$, and so on, until returning to $uv$ from $u$.

The input to each algorithm we'll discuss will be a weakly triangulated plane graph $G$ with $n = |V(G)|$ vertices and $m = |E(G)|$ edges. The input size will be $n$, but it is equivalent to take $m$ to be the input size: if $n \geq 3$, then $m \leq 3n - 6$ by Euler's formula.

A connected planar graph may be embedded (by finding a rotation scheme induced by an embedding) and triangulated (by adding edges across faces that are not 3-cycles) in $\mathcal{O}(n)$ time, see e.g. Hopcroft and Tarjan [8] or Boyer and Myrvold [1]. Therefore, since the removal of any edges that were added to produce a triangulation will not invalidate a path coloring, we may consider each algorithm to take an arbitrary planar graph with $n$ vertices as its input, with no change to the time complexity.

We will represent the input plane graph $G$ via *adjacency lists*: a list, for each vertex $v$, of the neighbors of $v$. Each list will be ordered according to the counter-clockwise rotation scheme induced by $G$'s embedding. A vertex will be represented by an integer $0 \ldots n-1$. In algorithms, $N(v)$ will refer to $v$'s adjacency list.

Let $v \in G$ and $u \in N(v)$. Define $\text{next}_v(u) \in N(v)$ to be the neighbor counter-clockwise from $u$ around $v$. In algorithms, ${}^v u$ will be a reference to $u$'s entry in the adjacency list $N(v)$. In this way, ${}^v u$ represents both $u$ and the relative position of the edge $uv$ around $v$ in the embedding. Define $\text{next}({}^v u) = {}^v(\text{next}_v(u))$ to be the next entry in the list $N(v)$.

The $\mathcal{O}(n)$ time complexity of the algorithm in Section 4 depends on our ability to compute a *back reference* $\text{back}({}^v u) = {}^u v$ in $\mathcal{O}(1)$ time. An *augmented adjacency list* stores a pair $(u, {}^u v)$ for each neighbor $u$ of $v$. Given an adjacency list representation, an augmented representation may be built in $\mathcal{O}(m)$ time, see Algorithm 2.1.

**Algorithm 2.1:** *Augment*$(N)$

**Input.** An adjacency list representation $N$ of a graph $G$.

**Output.** An augmented adjacency list representation $N^*$ of $G$ with the same rotation scheme as $N$.

**Step 1.** For each $v \in G$, construct an augmented adjacency list $N^*(v)$ with the same ordering as $N(v)$, leaving the ${}^u v$ portion of each entry $(u, {}^u v)$ in $N^*(v)$ uninitialized.

**Step 2.** For each vertex $v$, construct a list $\text{Wrk}(v)$ of vertex-reference pairs with capacity $\deg(v)$. For each $v$ from 0 to $n-1$, iterate through $N^*(v)$. For each neighbor $u$ in $N^*(v)$, append the pair $(v, {}^v u)$ to $\text{Wrk}(u)$, where ${}^v u$ is a reference to $u$'s entry $N^*(v)$.

**Step 3.** For each $v$ from $n-1$ to 0, iterate through $\text{Wrk}(v)$. Upon reaching a pair $(u, {}^u v)$ in $\text{Wrk}(v)$, the last element of $\text{Wrk}(u)$ will be $(v, {}^v u)$; see below. Lookup the entry ${}^v u$ in $N^*(v)$ and initialize the back reference ${}^u v$, and vice versa. Pop $(v, {}^v u)$ from $\text{Wrk}(u)$.

After completing Step 2 in Algorithm 2.1 each list $\text{Wrk}(v)$ will contain $(u, {}^u v)$ for each neighbor $u$ of $v$, sorted in increasing order by $u$. Suppose that $v$ is the current vertex at a given iteration of the loop in Step 3. For each edge $uw \in E(G)$ such that $u < w$ and $v < w$, prior iterations of the loop will have initialized the back references for $(w, {}^w u)$ in $N^*(u)$ and $(u, {}^u w)$ in $N^*(w)$, and removed $(w, {}^w u)$ from $\text{Wrk}(u)$. Therefore, for each $(u, {}^u v)$ in $\text{Wrk}(v)$, the list $\text{Wrk}(u)$ will only contain entries $(w, {}^w u)$ where $w \leq v$.

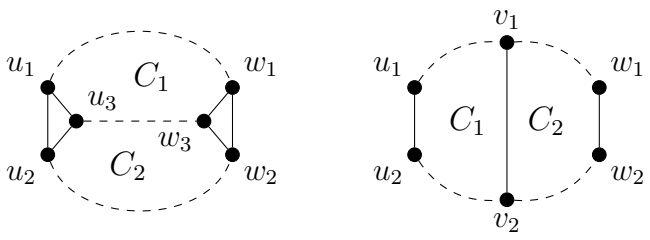



Figure 1: The proof of Lemma 3.1 when $C$ is induced (left), or has a chord (right).

# 3 Path Coloring

In this section we describe a linear time algorithm to path 3-color a plane graph, based on Poh's constructive proof of Theorem 1.1.

Let $C$ be a cycle in a connected plane graph $G$. If $u, v \in C$, then we define $C[u, v]$ to be the clockwise $u, v$-path along $C$; if $u = v$, then $C[u, u] = u$. Define $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ to be the subgraph of $G$ consisting of $C$ and all vertices and edges interior to $C$; equivalently, $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ is the maximal subgraph of $G$ with outer face $C$. Define $\text{int}(C) = \overline{\text{int}}(C) - C$.

Let $P$ be a path in a plane graph $G$. If $u, v \in P$, then we define $P[u, v]$ to be the $u, v$-path in $P$. We also define $\overline{\text{int}}(P) = P$ and $\text{int}(P)$ to be empty.

**Lemma 3.1** (Poh 1990)**.** *Let $G$ be a biconnected, weakly triangulated plane graph with outer cycle $C$. Let $c : V(C) \to S \subsetneq \{1, 2, 3\}$ be a 2-coloring of $C$ such that each color class induces a nonempty path. There exists an extension of $c$ to a path 3-coloring $c : V(G) \to \{1, 2, 3\}$ such that for each $v \in G - C$, if $vu \in E(G)$ with $u \in C$, then $c(v) \neq c(u)$.*

*Proof.* If $|V(G)| \leq 3$, then $G = C$. We proceed by induction on the order of $G$.

Suppose that $G \neq C$. Let $P_1, P_2$ be the two paths induced by the 2-coloring of the outer face $C$. We may write $P_1 = C[u_1, w_1]$ and $P_2 = C[w_2, u_2]$ for vertices $u_1, u_2, w_1, w_2 \in C$.

Suppose that $C$ is an induced subgraph of $G$. Take $u_3, w_3 \in G - C$ such that the cycles $u_3, u_2, u_1$ and $w_3, w_1, w_2$ are faces of $G$; note that $u_3$ and $w_3$ are uniquely determined, but it may be that $u_3 = w_3$. Since $C$ is induced, $G - C$ is connected. Let $P_3$ be an induced $u_3, w_3$-path in $G - C$. Color each vertex of $P_3$ with $d \in \{1, 2, 3\} - S$. Let $C_1 = P_1 \cup P_3 \cup u_3u_1 \cup w_3w_1$ and $C_2 = P_2 \cup P_3 \cup u_3u_2 \cup w_3w_2$, see Figure 1 (left). By the inductive hypothesis, the 2-coloring of $C_1$ extends to a path 3-coloring of $\overline{\text{int}}(C_1)$. Similarly, the coloring of $C_2$ extends to a path 3-coloring of $\overline{\text{int}}(C_2)$. Together these colorings form a 3-coloring of $G$. Since $C$, $P_3$, $\text{int}(C_1)$, and $\text{int}(C_2)$ partition $V(G)$, and no vertex shares a color with a neighbor in a different partition, this 3-coloring is a path coloring satisfying the lemma.

Suppose that $C$ is not an induced subgraph. Then there exists an edge $v_1v_2 \in E(G) - E(C)$ with $v_1 \in P_1$ and $v_2 \in P_2$. Let $C_1 = C[v_2, v_1] \cup v_1v_2$ and $C_2 = C[v_1, v_2] \cup v_1v_2$, see Figure 1 (right). By the inductive hypothesis, $c$ extends to path 3-colorings of $\overline{\text{int}}(C_1)$ and $\overline{\text{int}}(C_2)$. Together these colorings form a path 3-coloring of $G$ satisfying the lemma. □

Let $G$ be a triangulated plane graph. We may trivially path 2-color the outer triangle. By Lemma 3.1 this extends to a path 3-coloring of $G$. If $G$ is an arbitrary planar graph,

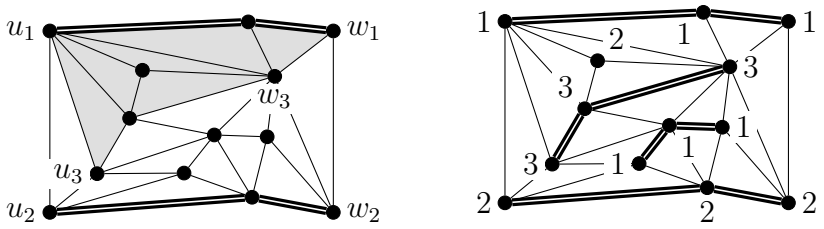



Figure 2: An example setup for Poh's algorithm highlighting the subgraph $G_1$ induced by $V(P_1) \cup N(P_1) - V(P_2)$ (left), and a path 3-coloring produced by Algorithm 3.2 (right).

we may compute an embedding and add edges to produce a triangulated plane graph $G'$. Theorem 1.1 follows immediately as any path coloring of $G'$ is also a path coloring of $G$.

Let $G$, $C$, $P_1$, and $P_2$ be as in the proof of Lemma 3.1, and assume $C$ is induced in $G$. For a subgraph $H$ of $G$, let $N(H)$ be the set of vertices in $G - H$ that have a neighbor in $H$. Let $G_1$ be the subgraph of $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ induced by $V(P_1) \cup N(P_1) - V(P_2)$, see Figure 2. Let $C_1$ be the outer face of $G_1$. Algorithm 3.2 implements Poh's algorithm in $\mathcal{O}(n)$ time by using $P_3 = C_1 - P_1 = C_1[w_3, u_3]$ as the $u_3, w_3$-path. Observe that $P_3$ is induced in $G$: $G_1$ is induced, so there is no chord of $P_3$ exterior to $C_1$, and each $v \in P_3$ has a neighbor in $P_1$, so there is no chord of $P_3$ interior to $C_1$. To compute $P_3$ in the algorithm: we'll mark the vertices in $G_1$, then walk counter-clockwise from $u_3$ to $w_3$ along the outer face $C_1$.

Define $p_1 : N(P_1) \to V(P_1)$ to be the map sending each $v \in N(P_1)$ to its neighbor in $P_1 = C[u_1, w_1]$ that is closest to $w_1$, i.e. $V(C[p_1(v), w_1]) \cap N(v) = \{p_1(v)\}$.

**Algorithm 3.2:** *Path3Color*$(u_1, {}^{u_1}u_2, \ell_1)$

**Input.** Let $C$ be an induced cycle in a weakly triangulated plane graph $G$ represented via adjacency lists. Let $c$ be a length $n$ array representing a 2-coloring of $C$ such that each color class induces a nonempty path, respectively $P_1 = C[u_1, w_1]$ and $P_2 = C[w_2, u_2]$, where $u_1, u_2, w_1, w_2 \in C$. Assume that $c(v) = 0$ for each $v \in \text{int}(C)$. Let $S$ be a length $n$ array, and $\ell_1$ an integer, such that for $v \in \text{int}(C)$, $S(v) = \ell_1$ if and only if $v \in N(P_1)$.

The concrete input will be $G$, $c$, and $S$, along with the tuple $(u_1, {}^{u_1}u_2, \ell_1)$.

**Output.** For each vertex $v \in \text{int}(C)$, a color in $\{1, 2, 3\}$ will be assigned to $c(v)$ such that $c$ represents a path 3-coloring of $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ extending the original 2-coloring of $C$. Moreover, if $v \in \text{int}(C)$ has a neighbor $u \in C$, then $c(v) \neq c(u)$.

**Procedure.** Let ${}^{u_1}u_3 := \text{next}({}^{u_1}u_2)$. It may be useful to refer to Figures 2 and 3.

**Base case.** If $c(u_3) \neq 0$, then $u_3 = w_2$ or $u_3 = w_1$. Thus $C$ is a face and we are done.

**Recursive case.** Suppose that $c(u_3) = 0$, i.e. $u_3 \in \text{int}(C)$. Let $\ell_3 := \max_{v \in G} S(v) + 1$. Let $d \in \{1, 2, 3\} - \{c(u_1), c(u_2)\}$. We'll walk the induced $u_3, w_3$-path $P_3 = C_1 - P_1$, where $C_1$ is the outer face of the subgraph $G_1$ of $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ induced by $V(P_1) \cup N(P_1) - V(P_2)$.

**Step 1.** Let $a := u_1$ and $z := u_3$; here $z$ stores the current vertex of $P_3$, and $a$ stores the vertex clockwise from $z$ around $C_1$. Let $t :=$ NULL and ${}^t x :=$ NULL; here $t$ and ${}^t x$ store the last edge $tx$ visited where $t \in P_3$ and $x \in P_2$ (the first such edge will be $u_3u_2$).

**Loop 2.** We'll walk counter-clockwise along $C_1$, coloring one vertex $z$ per iteration, and halt after $z = w_3$. Color $c(z) \leftarrow d$. Find ${}^z a$ in $N(z)$ and let ${}^z v := \text{next}({}^z a)$. Let

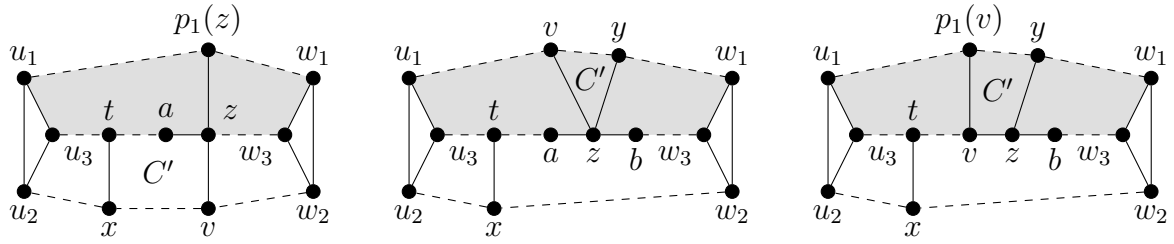



Figure 3: A sketch of Case 2.1.2 (left), Case 2.2.2 (middle), and Case 2.2.3 (right) in Algorithm 3.2. In each sketch, the highlighted region represents $G_1$.

$b :=$ NULL; here $b$ will store the vertex in $P_3$ counter-clockwise from $z$ around $C_1$, if such a vertex exists. Let ${}^zy :=$ NULL; here ${}^zy$ will store the last edge $zy$ visited where $y \in P_1$.

**Loop 2.1.** We'll first consider the neighbors of $z$ from $\text{next}_z(a)$ to $p_1(z)$ counter-clockwise. Each iteration will handle one neighbor ${}^zv$. We'll make a recursive call on each induced cycle $C'$ in $G$ that satisfies $V(C') \subseteq V(P_2) \cup V(P_3)$ and $C' \cap P_3[z, w_3] = z$.

**Case 2.1.1.** Suppose that $c(v) = 0$, i.e. $v \in \text{int}(C)$. If $S(v) = \ell_1$ and $b =$ NULL, then $v \in P_3$ and we set $b \leftarrow v$. Set $S(v) \leftarrow \ell_3$ and ${}^zv \leftarrow \text{next}({}^zv)$. Repeat Loop 2.1.

**Case 2.1.2.** Suppose $c(v) = c(u_2)$, i.e. $v \in P_2$. If $t \neq$ NULL, call *Path3Color*$(t, {}^tx, \ell_3)$ to color $\overline{\text{int}}(C')$, where $C' = P_3[t, z] \cup C[v, x] \cup tx \cup zv$; refer to Figure 3 (left). Set $t \leftarrow z$, ${}^tx \leftarrow {}^zv$, and ${}^zv \leftarrow \text{next}({}^zv)$. Repeat Loop 2.1.

**Case 2.1.3.** Suppose that $c(v) = c(u_1)$, i.e. $v = p_1(z) \in P_1$. Break Loop 2.1. If $v = a$, skip to Step 2.3. Otherwise, set ${}^zy \leftarrow {}^zv$, ${}^zv \leftarrow \text{next}({}^zv)$, and proceed to Loop 2.2.

**Loop 2.2.** We'll now consider the neighbors of $z$ from $\text{next}_z(p_1(z))$ to $a$ counter-clockwise. Each iteration will handle one neighbor ${}^zv$. We'll make a recursive call on each induced cycle $C'$ that satisfies $V(C') \subseteq V(P_1) \cup V(P_3)$ and $C' \cap P_3[z, w_3] = z$.

**Case 2.2.1.** Suppose that $c(v) = 0$, i.e. $v \in \text{int}(C_1)$. Assign $S(v) \leftarrow \ell_3$ and ${}^zv \leftarrow \text{next}({}^zv)$. Repeat Loop 2.2.

**Case 2.2.2.** Suppose that $c(v) \neq 0$ and $v \neq a$, i.e. $v \in P_1$. Call *Path3Color*$(z, {}^zy, \ell_3)$ to color $\overline{\text{int}}(C')$, where $C' = C[v, y] \cup z \cup zy \cup zv$; see Figure 3 (middle). Set ${}^zy \leftarrow {}^zv$ and ${}^zv \leftarrow \text{next}({}^zv)$, then repeat Loop 2.2.

**Case 2.2.3.** Suppose $v = a$. Call *Path3Color*$(z, {}^zy, \ell_3)$ to color $\overline{\text{int}}(C')$, where $C' = C[p_1(v), y] \cup P_3[v, z] \cup vp_1(v) \cup zy$; see Figure 3 (right). Break Loop 2.2 and go to Step 2.3.

**Step 2.3.** If $b \neq$ NULL, then assign $a \leftarrow z$, $z \leftarrow b$, and repeat Loop 2. Otherwise, $z = w_3$ and $c$ is a path 3-coloring of $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$, so we are done.

Given a triangulated plane graph $G$ represented via adjacency lists, we can apply Algorithm 3.2 as follows. First, create length $n$ integer arrays for $c$ and $S$, initializing each entry to zero. Let $C = v_1, v_2, v_3$ be the outer triangle of $G$, labeled in clockwise order. Color $c(v_1) \leftarrow 1$, $c(v_2) \leftarrow 2$, and $c(v_3) \leftarrow 2$. Iterate through $N(v_1)$ and mark $S(v) \leftarrow 1$ for each neighbor $v$ of $v_1$. Then call *Path3Color*$(v_1, {}^{v_1}v_3, 1)$ with $G$, $c$, and $S$.

During Algorithm 3.2, $N(z)$ is iterated exactly twice for each $z \in G$: once to locate ${}^za$ at the start of Loop 2, and once in Loops 2.1 and 2.2. Thus its time complexity is $\mathcal{O}(n)$.

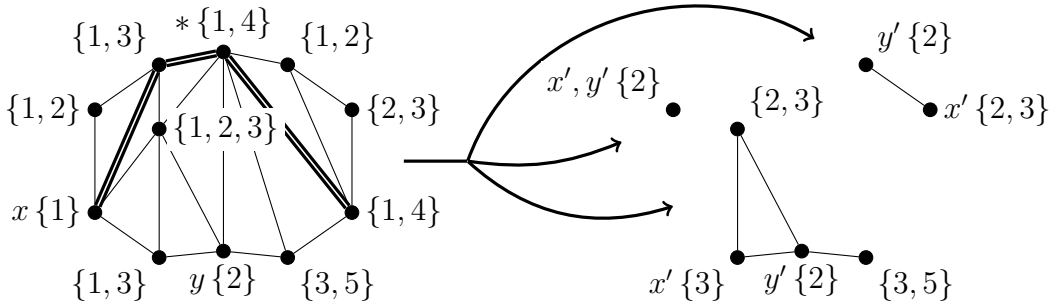



Figure 4: Coloring and removing a path $P$ as in Hartman's proof [7, Lemma 4.2].

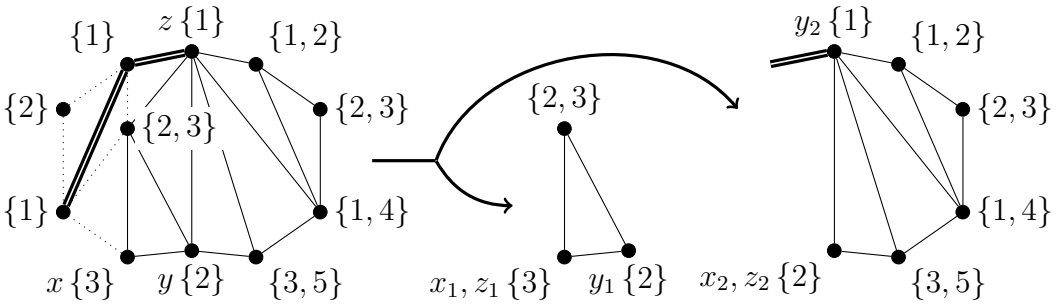



Figure 5: Coloring and removing a path $P$ as in the proof of Lemma 4.1 (Algorithm 4.2).

# 4 Path List-Coloring

In this section we describe a linear time algorithm to path color a plane graph such that each vertex receives a color from a specified list of three colors, based on Hartman's constructive proof of Theorem 1.2.

Hartman's algorithm takes as its input a weakly triangulated plane graph $G$ with outer face $C$, a list assignment $L$, and vertices $x, y \in C$. It assumes $|L(v)| \geq 1$ if $v \in \{x, y\} \cup S$, $|L(v)| \geq 2$ if $v \in C - \{x, y\} \cup S$, and $|L(v)| \geq 3$ if $v \in G - C$, where $S$ is the set of cut-vertices separating $x$ from $y$. An induced path $P$ is colored with $d \in L(x)$, proceeding from $x$ towards $y$ along $C[x, y]$. Starting from the single vertex $P = x$, the path $P$ is constructed as follows: let $z$ be the end of $P$ opposite $x$, and $T_z = \{v \in N(z) \cap V(C[z, y]) : d \in L(v)\}$; if $T_z \neq \emptyset$, then the $v \in T_z$ closest to $y$ in $C[z, y]$ is colored and added to $P$; this process is then repeated (with $z = v$) until $T_z = \emptyset$. The algorithm is then recursively applied to each connected component of $G - P$, using the list assignment $L'$ defined by $L'(v) = L(v) - \{d\}$ if $v \in N(P)$, and $L'(v) = L(v)$ if $v \notin N(P)$. See Figure 4 for an example.

In Lemma 4.1 below, we provide a different proof of Hartman's result, organized in such a way that it immediately describes a linear time algorithm for graphs represented as in Section 2. If $x = z$, then our $G, x, y$ match Hartman's, but we assume that $G$ is biconnected (so $S = \emptyset$); we follow a similar procedure to color a path $P$ clockwise from $x$

along $C[x, y]$, but we consider one edge at a time, and simultaneously remove $P$ from $G$ as it is colored. If $x \neq z$, then $z$ is the farthest clockwise end of the path $P$ being colored; the rest of $P$ (if any) has already been removed, and our $x$ serves as Hartman's $x'$.

The one major difference between our algorithm and Hartman's occurs in Case 3.2.3.2 of the proof of Lemma 4.1 below. If we encounter a chord edge $zv \in E(G) - E(C)$ (here $z$ is the current end of $P$) with $v \in C[z, y]$ and $L(z) \cap L(v) = \emptyset$ (i.e. $d \notin L(v)$, where $d$ is the color of $P$), then instead of continuing to search for neighbors of $z$ in $C[z, v]$ that we might add to $P$, we apply the inductive hypothesis such that $z$ now serves as "$y$". In Figure 4, the edge from the vertex labeled $*$ to $y$ is such a chord: our algorithm would halt $P$ at $*$, and divide the remaining subgraph at the chord, see Figure 5. For a general illustration of this case, see Figure 8.

Given a coloring $c$ of a graph $G$, and $v \in G$, we define $\deg_c(v)$ to be $\deg(v)$ in the subgraph induced by $c(v)$'s color class, i.e. the number of neighbors that share $v$'s color.

**Lemma 4.1.** *Let $G$ be a biconnected, weakly triangulated plane graph with outer cycle $C$. Let $x, y, z \in C$ be vertices (not necessarily distinct) such that $z \in C[x, y]$. Let $L$ be a list assignment of $G$ such that*

$$|L(v)| = 1 \text{ for } v \in \{x, y, z\},$$
$$|L(v)| \geq 2 \text{ for } v \in C - \{x, y, z\},$$
$$|L(v)| \geq 3 \text{ for } v \in G - C,$$

*and if $v \in C[x, z] - z$, then $L(v) \cap L(z) = \emptyset$. There exists a path $L$-list-coloring $c$ of $G$ such that $\deg_c(x) \leq 1$, $\deg_c(y) \leq 1$, and $\deg_c(z) \leq 1$. Moreover, if $z = y$, or if $C[z, y] = z, y$ and $L(z) \cap L(y) = \emptyset$, then $\deg_c(z) = 0$.*

*Proof.* Suppose that $m = |E(G)| \leq 1$. We define the path $L$-list-coloring $c$ of $G = C$ as follows. Let $c(x) \in L(x)$ and $c(y) \in L(y)$ be the color in each respective list. If $m = 0$, then $|V(G)| = 1$ and $c$ trivially satisfies the lemma. Otherwise $m = 1$ and $|V(G)| = 2$. If $x = y$, then the vertex $v \in G - y$ satisfies $|L(v)| \geq 2$, so define $c(v) \in L(v) - L(y)$. Note that $\deg_c(v) \leq 1$ for each $v \in G$, with $\deg_c(z) = 1$ only if $z \neq y$ and $L(z) = L(y)$.

We proceed by induction on $m$, the number of edges. Let $u_1, u_2, \ldots, u_k$ label the neighbors of $z$ in counter-clockwise order such that $u_1$ is the vertex immediately counter-clockwise from $z$ around $C$, and $u_k$ is the vertex clockwise from $z$ around $C$. In each of the subsequent cases we will apply the lemma separately to one or two subgraphs $G_1, G_2$ of $G$, with corresponding outer face vertices labeled $x_i, y_i, z_i \in G_i$ for $i = 1, 2$.

**Case 1.** Suppose that $u_1 = y$. Note that $z = x$ since $z \in C[x, y]$. Therefore $V(C[z, y]) = V(C)$, so $|V(C[z, y])| \geq 3$ and $C[z, y] \neq z, y$. Apply the lemma to find a path $L$-list-coloring $c$ of $G_1 = G$ with $x_1 = y$, $y_1 = x$, and $z_1 = y$, see Figure 6 (left).

**Case 2.** Suppose that $u_1 \neq y$ and $z = x$. Then $u_1 \in C - C[x, z]$ and $|L(u_1)| \geq 2$. Pick $d \in L(u_1) - L(z)$. Define $L'(u_1) = \{d\}$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G - u_1$. Find a path $L'$-list-coloring of $G_1 = G$ with $x_1 = u_1$, $y_1 = y$, and $z_1 = z$, see Figure 6 (middle).

**Case 3.** Suppose that $u_1 \neq y$ and $z \neq x$. Our strategy will be to apply the inductive hypothesis to the *blocks* (maximal biconnected subgraphs) of $G - zu_1$. Because $u_1 \in$

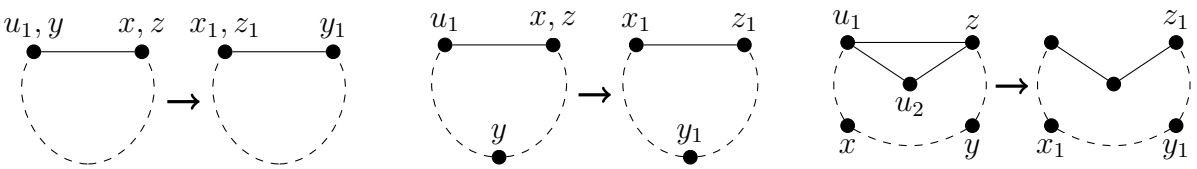



Figure 6: The proof of Lemma 4.1, Case 1 (left), Case 2 (middle), and Case 3.1 (right).

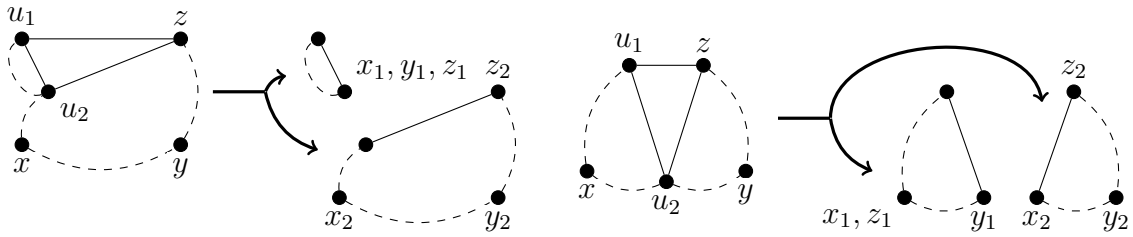



Figure 7: The proof of Lemma 4.1, Case 3.2.1 (left) and Case 3.2.2 (right).

$C[x, z]$, we have $L(u_1) \cap L(z) = \emptyset$. Thus any path $L$-list-coloring of $G - zu_1$ is also a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. There are three cases to consider, see Figures 6 (right), 7, and 8.

**Case 3.1.** Suppose that $u_2 \in G - C$. Define $L'(u_2) = L(u_2) - L(z)$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G - u_2$. Note that $|L'(u_2)| \geq |L(u_2)| - 1 \geq 2$. Let $C_1$ be the outer face of $G_1 = G - zu_1$, and observe that $C_1[x, z]$ is the union of $C[x, z] - u_1z$ with the path $u_1, u_2, z$. Since $|L'(u_2)| \geq 2$ and $L'(u_2) \cap L'(z) = \emptyset$, we may apply the inductive hypothesis to find a path $L'$-list-coloring of $G_1$ with $x_1 = x$, $y_1 = y$, $z_1 = z$.

**Case 3.2.** Suppose that $u_2 \in C$. Observe that $u_2$ is a *cut-vertex* of $G - zu_1$, i.e. $G - zu_1 - u_2$ is disconnected. Define $C_1 = C[u_2, u_1] \cup u_1u_2$ and $C_2 = C[z, u_2] \cup zu_2$. Let $G_1 = \overline{\text{int}}(C_1)$ and $G_2 = \overline{\text{int}}(C_2)$. The subgraphs $G_1$ and $G_2$ are the two blocks of $G - zu_1$.

In each subsequent case we will apply the inductive hypothesis to find a path $L$-list-coloring $c_1$ of $G_1$ and a path $L$-list-coloring $c_2$ of $G_2$ such that $c_1(u_2) = c_2(u_2)$. Let $c$ be the $L$-list-coloring of $G$ defined by $v \mapsto c_1(v)$ for $v \in G_1$ and $v \mapsto c_2(v)$ for $v \in G_2$. Observe that $\deg_c(v) = \deg_{c_1}(v)$ for each $v \in G_1 - u_2$, $\deg_c(v) = \deg_{c_2}(v)$ for each $v \in G_2 - u_2$, and $\deg_c(u_2) = \deg_{c_1}(u_2) + \deg_{c_2}(u_2)$. To show that $c$ is a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$ it suffices to show that $\deg_c(u_2) \leq 2$.

**Case 3.2.1.** Suppose that $u_2 \in C[x, z]$. Observe that $x, y, z \in C_2$. Apply the inductive hypothesis to find a path $L$-list-coloring $c_2$ of $G_2$ with $x_2 = x$, $y_2 = y$, and $z_2 = z$. Define $L'(u_2) = \{c_2(u_2)\}$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G_1 - u_2$. Find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_1$ of $G_1$ with $x_1 = y_1 = z_1 = u_2$. Since $\deg_{c_1}(u_2) = 0$, $c$ is a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. Moreover, since $\deg_c(v) = \deg_{c_2}(v)$ for all $v \in G_2$, the $\deg_c$ constraints for $x, y, z$ follow from the inductive hypothesis.

**Case 3.2.2.** Suppose that $u_2 \in C[y, x] - x - y$. Pick $d \in L(u_2) - L(z)$. Define $L'(u_2) = \{d\}$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G - u_2$. Observe that $x \in C_1$ and $z, y \in C_2$. Apply the inductive hypothesis to find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_1$ of $G_1$ with $x_1 = z_1 = x$ and $y_1 = u_2$. Then find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_2$ of $G_2$ with $x_2 = u_2$, $y_2 = y$, and

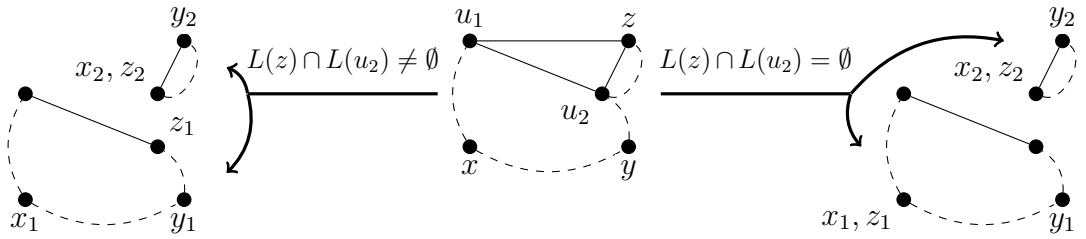



Figure 8: The proof of Lemma 4.1, Case 3.2.3.

$z_2 = z$. Since $\deg_{c_1}(u_2) \leq 1$ and $\deg_{c_2}(u_2) \leq 1$, $c$ is a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. Since $\deg_c(x) = \deg_{c_1}(x_1)$, $\deg_c(y) = \deg_{c_2}(y_2)$, and $\deg_c(z) = \deg_{c_2}(z_2)$, the $\deg_c$ constraints again follow from the inductive hypotheses.

**Case 3.2.3.** Suppose that $u_2 \in C[z, y]$. Note that $z \neq y$. There are two cases to consider, see Figure 8.

**Case 3.2.3.1.** Suppose that $L(z) \cap L(u_2) \neq \emptyset$. Then either $u_2 = y$ and $L(z) = L(y)$, or $C[z, y] \neq z, y$. Define $L'(u_2) = L(z)$, and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G - u_2$. Find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_1$ of $G_1$ with $x_1 = x$, $y_1 = y$, and $z_1 = u_2$. Then find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_2$ of $G_2$ with $x_2 = u_2$, $y_2 = z$, and $z_2 = u_2$. Since $\deg_{c_1}(u_2) \leq 1$ and $\deg_{c_2}(u_2) = 1$, it follows that $c$ is a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. If $u_2 = y$, then $z_1 = y_1 = y$ and $\deg_{c_1}(y) = 0$; thus $\deg_c(y) = \deg_{c_2}(u_2) = 1$. If $u_2 \neq y$, then $\deg_c(y) = \deg_{c_1}(y_1) \leq 1$. In either case, $\deg_c(z) = \deg_{c_2}(y_2) = 1$ and $\deg_c(x) = \deg_{c_1}(x_1) \leq 1$.

**Case 3.2.3.2.** Suppose that $L(z) \cap L(u_2) = \emptyset$. Find a path $L$-list-coloring $c_1$ of $G_1$ with $x_1 = x$, $y_1 = y$, and $z_1 = x$. Define $L'(u_2) = \{c_1(u_2)\}$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for each $v \in G_2 - u_2$. Then find a path $L'$-list-coloring $c_2$ of $G_2$ with $x_2 = u_2$, $y_2 = z$, and $z_2 = u_2$. Because $C[z_2, y_2] = z_2, y_2$ and $L'(z_2) \cap L'(y_2) = \emptyset$, we must have $\deg_{c_2}(u_2) = \deg_{c_2}(z_2) = 0$. Thus $c$ is a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. Moreover, $\deg_c(x) = \deg_{c_1}(x_1) \leq 1$, $\deg_c(y) = \deg_{c_1}(y_1) \leq 1$, and $\deg_c(z) = \deg_{c_2}(y_2) \leq 1$. If $C[z, y] = z, y$, then $G_2 = z, y$ and $\deg_c(z) = 0$, since $c(z) \notin L(y)$. $\square$

Let $G$ be a planar graph and $L$ a list assignment such that $|L(v)| \geq 3$ for each $v \in G$. Compute a planar embedding and add edges to produce a triangulated plane graph $G'$. Pick $u \in G'$ on the outer face and $d \in L(u)$. Define the list assignment $L'$ by $L'(u) = \{d\}$ and $L'(v) = L(v)$ for $v \in G' - u$. By Lemma 4.1 there exists a path $L'$-list-coloring of $G'$, and thus a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$. So Theorem 1.2 follows from Lemma 4.1.

The proof of Lemma 4.1 describes a linear time path list-coloring algorithm, see Algorithm 4.2. Given $v \in G$ and any entry ${}^v u$ in $N(v)$, we'll assume the entry $\text{back}({}^v u) = {}^u v$ in $N(u)$ may be computed in $\mathcal{O}(1)$ time; see augmented adjacency lists in Section 2.

**Algorithm 4.2:** *Path3Choose*$(x, y, z)$

**Input.** Let $C$ be a cycle or length 1 path in a weakly triangulated plane graph $G$ represented via augmented adjacency lists. Let $x, y, z \in C$ be such that $z \in C[x, y]$.

Let $L$ be a length $n$ array of lists of colors such that for $v \in \{x, y, z\}$ each list $L(v)$ has length one, for $v \in C - \{x, y, z\}$ each list $L(v)$ has length two or three, and for $v \in \text{int}(C)$

each list $L(v)$ has length three. Furthermore, for each $v \in C[x,z] - z$, assume that $L(v)$ does not contain the color in $L(z)$.

Let $A, B$ be length $n$ arrays such that for each vertex $v \in C$ we have $A(v) = {}^{v}a$ and $B(v) = {}^{v}b$, where $a$ is the vertex immediately clockwise from $v$ around $C$, and $b$ is the vertex immediately counter clockwise from $v$ around $C$.

Let $S$ be a length $n$ integer array such that, for $v \in \overline{\text{int}}(C)$, $S(v) \neq 0$ if and only if $v \in C$, and $S(v) = S(x)$ if and only if $v \in C[x,z] - z$ (or $v = x = z$).

We'll write $m_C = |E(\overline{\text{int}}(C))|$ and $\max(S) = \max_{v \in G} S(v)$. Define $\ell = \max(S) + r$, with $r$ determined by the case below that the input satisfies: if $m_C = 1$ (Base case) or $z \neq x$ (Case 3), then $r = 0$; if $z = x$ and $C[y,x] \neq y, x$ (Case 2), then $r = 1$; otherwise $z = x$ and $C[y,x] = y, x$ (Case 1), and $r = 2$. We'll assume that $\ell < 2(m - m_C + 1) + 2$.

Let $M$ be a length $2m + 2$ integer array such that if $v \in C$, then $M(S(v)) = S(y)$ if and only if $v \in C[z,y]$. The purpose of the array $M$ is described below in Case 3.2.3.2.

The concrete input will be $G$, $L$, $A$, $B$, $S$, $M$, along with the tuple $(x, y, z)$.

**Output.** For each $v \in \overline{\text{int}}(C)$, all but one color will be removed from the list $L(v)$. The remaining color in each list will represent a path $L$-list-coloring of $\overline{\text{int}}(C)$ such that $\deg_c(x) \leq 1$, $\deg_c(y) \leq 1$, and $\deg_c(z) \leq 1$. If $z = y$, or if $C[z,y] = z, y$ and $L(z)$ did not contain the color in $L(y)$, then $\deg_c(z) = 0$. We'll also guarantee $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$.

**Procedure.** Let ${}^{z}u_1 := B(z)$. Our strategy will follow the proof of Lemma 4.1.

**Base case.** If $A(z) = B(z)$, then $C = z, u_1$ is a length 1 path. If $u_1 \neq x$ and $u_1 \neq y$, remove the color in $L(z)$ from $L(u_1)$, if it exists, then remove further colors until one color remains. Note that $m_C = 1$ and $\max(S) = \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$ by definition.

**Recursive case.** Suppose that $A(z) \neq B(z)$. Let ${}^{z}u_2 := \text{next}({}^{z}u_1)$. It follows from the definition of $\ell$ that $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$ after Cases 1, 2, and 3.1, so we will only argue why the bound holds after Case 3.2. It may be useful to see Figures 6, 7, and 8.

**Case 1.** Suppose that $u_1 = y$. Then $z = x$, since $z \in C[x,y]$. Set $S(x) \leftarrow \max(S) + 1$ and $S(y) \leftarrow S(x)$. Assign $M(S(x)) \leftarrow S(x)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(y, x, y)$.

**Case 2.** Suppose that $z = x$ and $u_1 \neq y$. Remove the color in $L(z)$ from $L(u_1)$, if it exists, then remove further colors until only one color remains. Assign $S(u_1) \leftarrow \max(S)+1$ and $M(S(u_1)) \leftarrow S(u_1)$, and call *Path3Choose*$(u_1, y, z)$.

**Case 3.** Suppose that $z \neq x$ and $u_1 \neq y$. Let ${}^{u_1}z := \text{back}({}^{z}u_1)$ and ${}^{u_2}z := \text{back}({}^{z}u_2)$. Remove the edge $zu_1$ by assigning $A(u_1) \leftarrow \text{back}(\text{next}({}^{u_2}z))$ and $B(z) \leftarrow \text{next}({}^{z}u_1)$.

**Case 3.1.** Suppose that $S(u_2) = 0$, i.e. $u_2 \in \text{int}(C)$. Assign $S(u_2) \leftarrow S(x)$, and initialize $B(u_2) \leftarrow {}^{u_2}u_1 = \text{next}({}^{u_2}z)$ and $A(u_2) \leftarrow {}^{u_2}z$, see Figure 6 (right). Remove the color in $L(z)$ from $L(u_2)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(x, y, z)$.

**Case 3.2.** Suppose that $S(u_2) \neq 0$, i.e. $u_2 \in C$. Just as in Case 3.2 of the proof of Lemma 4.1, we will separately consider the two blocks $G_1$ and $G_2$ of $\overline{\text{int}}(C) - zu_1$. Note that $m_C - 1 = |E(G_1)| + |E(G_2)|$.

As we've already removed the edge $zu_1$ by adjusting $B(z)$ and $A(u_1)$, it remains to "split" the neighborhood of $u_2$ at the edge $u_2z$ such that the recursive call on $G_1$ considers only the neighbors of $u_2$ counter-clockwise from $z$, and the call on $G_2$ considers $z$ and all neighbors clockwise from $z$; refer to Figure 7 and Figure 8.

Let ${}^{u_2}a := A(u_2)$ and ${}^{u_2}b := B(u_2)$. To represent $G_1$, we will assign $A(u_2) \leftarrow {}^{u_2}a$ and

$B(u_2) \leftarrow \text{next}({}^{u_2}z)$. To represent $G_2$, we'll assign $A(u_2) \leftarrow {}^{u_2}z$ and $B(u_2) \leftarrow {}^{u_2}b$

**Case 3.2.1.** Suppose that $S(u_2) = S(x)$, i.e. $u_2 \in C[x, z]$. Call *Path3Choose*$(x, y, z)$ on $G_2$ (by modifying $A(u_2)$ and $B(u_2)$ as above). Afterwards $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| - 2$. Assign $S(u_2) \leftarrow \max(S) + 1$ and $M(S(u_2)) \leftarrow S(u_2)$, and call *Path3Choose*$(u_2, u_2, u_2)$ on $G_1$. Finally, observe that $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| - 2 + 1 + 2|E(G_2)| - 1 < \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$.

**Case 3.2.2.** Suppose that $S(u_2) \neq 0$, but $S(u_2) \neq S(x)$ and $M(S(u_2)) \neq S(y)$. In other words, suppose that $u_2 \in C[y, x] - x - y$. First remove the color in $L(z)$ from $L(u_2)$, if it exists, then remove further colors until only one remains. Set $S(u_2) \leftarrow S(x)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(x, u_2, x)$ on $G_1$. Afterwards $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)|$. Set $S(u_2) \leftarrow \max(S) + 1$ and $M(S(u_2)) \leftarrow S(u_2)$, and call *Path3Choose*$(u_2, y, z)$ on $G_2$. Finally, observe that $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| + 1 + 2|E(G_2)| - 2 < \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$.

**Case 3.2.3.** Suppose that $M(S(u_2)) = S(y)$, i.e. $u_2 \in C[z, y]$. There are two cases to consider, see Figure 8.

**Case 3.2.3.1.** Suppose that the color in $L(z)$ is also in $L(u_2)$. Remove all colors from $L(u_2)$ except for the color in $L(z)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(x, y, u_2)$ on $G_1$. Afterwards $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| - 2$. Set $S(z) \leftarrow \max(S) + 1$, $S(u_2) \leftarrow S(z)$, and $M(S(z)) \leftarrow S(z)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(u_2, z, u_2)$ on $G_2$. Finally, observe that $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| - 2 + 1 + 2|E(G_2)| - 1 < \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$.

**Case 3.2.3.2.** Suppose the color in $L(z)$ is not in $L(u_2)$. Set $M(S(x)) \leftarrow S(y)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(x, y, x)$ on $G_1$. Afterwards $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)|$. Set $S(z) \leftarrow \max(S) + 1$, $S(u_2) \leftarrow S(z)$, and $M(S(z)) \leftarrow S(z)$. Call *Path3Choose*$(u_2, z, u_2)$ on $G_2$. Observe that $\max(S) \leq \ell + 2|E(G_1)| + 1 + 2|E(G_2)| - 1 = \ell + 2(m_C - 1)$.

Note that this is the only case where $M(S(v))$ is set a value other than $S(v)$. Setting $M(S(x)) \leftarrow S(y)$ effectively "joins" $C[x, u_1]$ onto $C[u_2, y]$ to represent $C_1[z_1, y_1]$ in $G_1$, see Figure 8. Without the array $M$, we'd need to re-mark each $v \in C[x, u_1]$ with $S(v) \leftarrow S(y)$.

Let $G$ be a triangulated plane graph represented by augmented adjacency lists. Let $L$ be a length $n$ array of color lists of length 3, representing a list assignment of $G$. We may path $L$-color $G$ using Algorithm 4.2 as follows.

Create length $n$ arrays $A, B$ and initialize $A(v)$ and $B(v)$ for each $v \in C$ on the outer face of $G$. Create a length $n$ integer array $S$ and initialize $S(v) \leftarrow 1$ for each $v \in C$ and $S(v) \leftarrow 0$ for each $v \in G - C$. Pick any $u \in C$, assign $S(u) \leftarrow 2$, and remove all but one color from $L(u)$. Create a length $2m + 2$ array of integers $M$ and initialize $M(i) \leftarrow i$ for each $i \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. Finally, call *Path3Choose*$(u, u, u)$ with $G$, $L$, $A$, $B$, $S$, and $M$. The remaining color in each list $L(v)$ will represent a path $L$-list-coloring of $G$.

Each case in Algorithm 4.2 performs a fixed number of constant time operations and makes up to two recursive calls. Case 3 removes an edge from the subgraph(s) under consideration. Case 1 makes a recursive call with an input that satisfies Case 2, and Case 2 makes a recursive call with an input that satisfies Case 3. Therefore the total number of recursive calls made, and thus overall the time complexity, is $\mathcal{O}(n)$.

See Figures 9 and 10 for a full example.

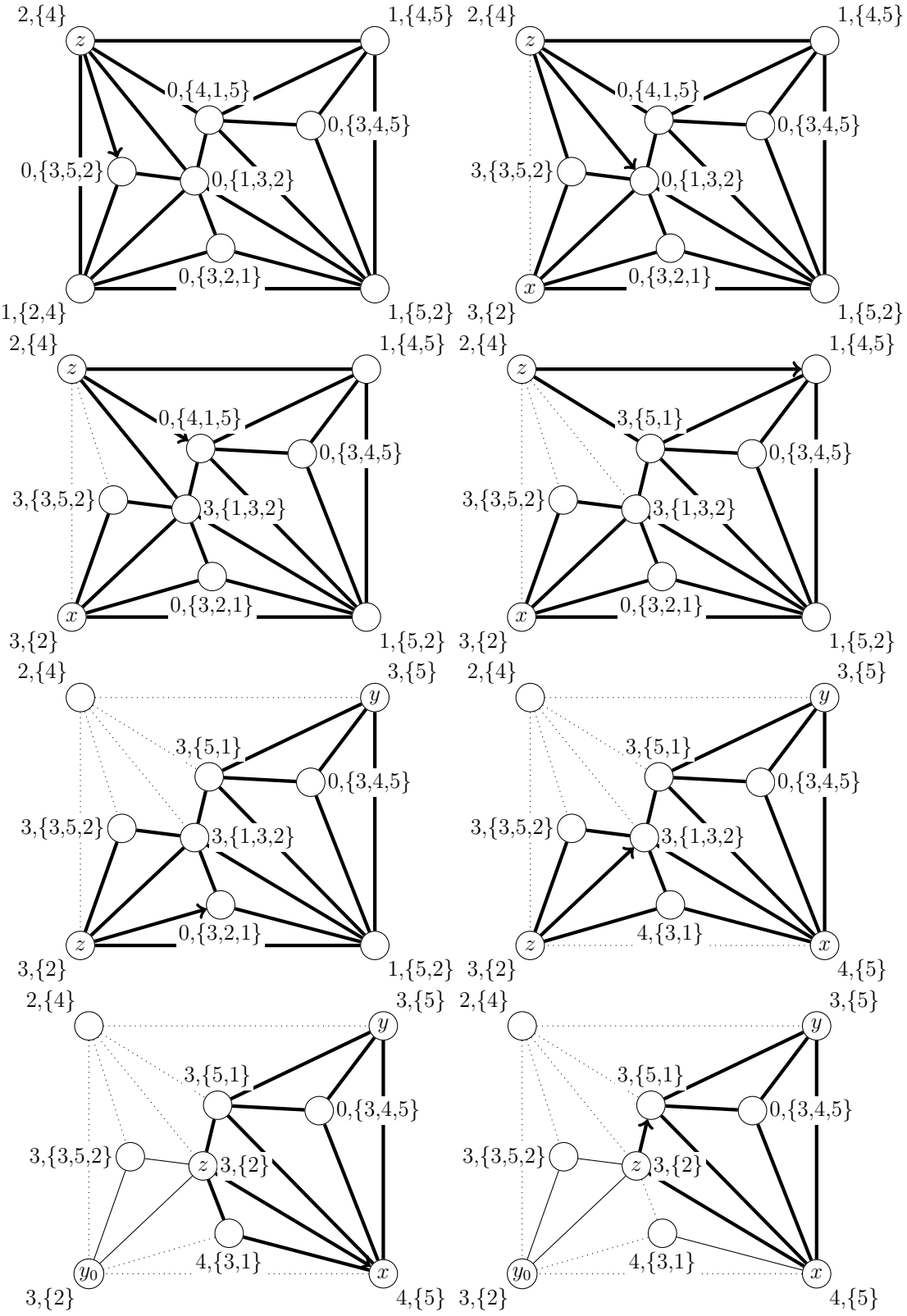



Figure 9: An example of Algorithm 4.2. Each vertex $v \in G$ is labeled with $S(v), L(v)$.

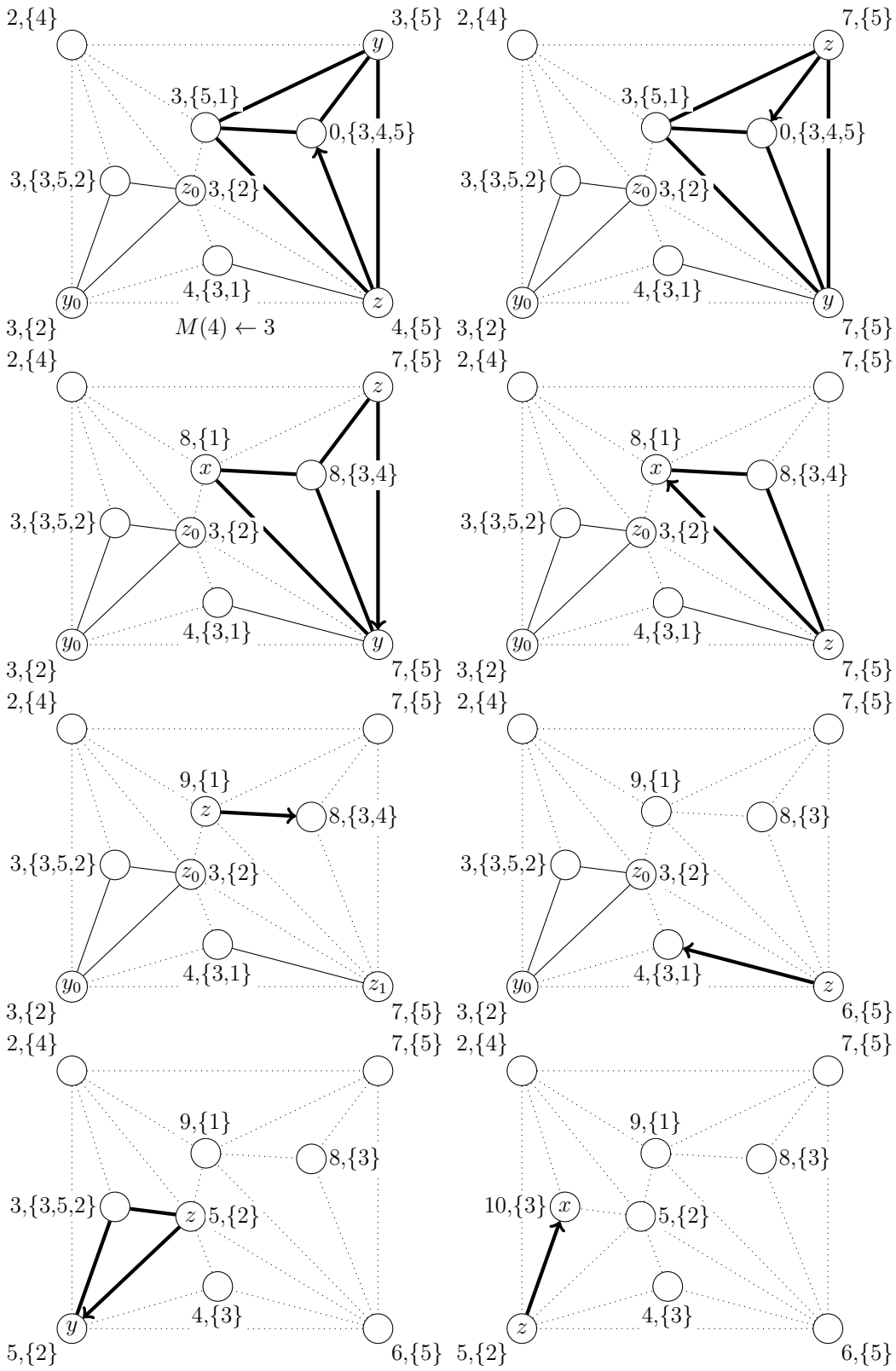



Figure 10: An Algorithm 4.2 example, continued from Figure 9.

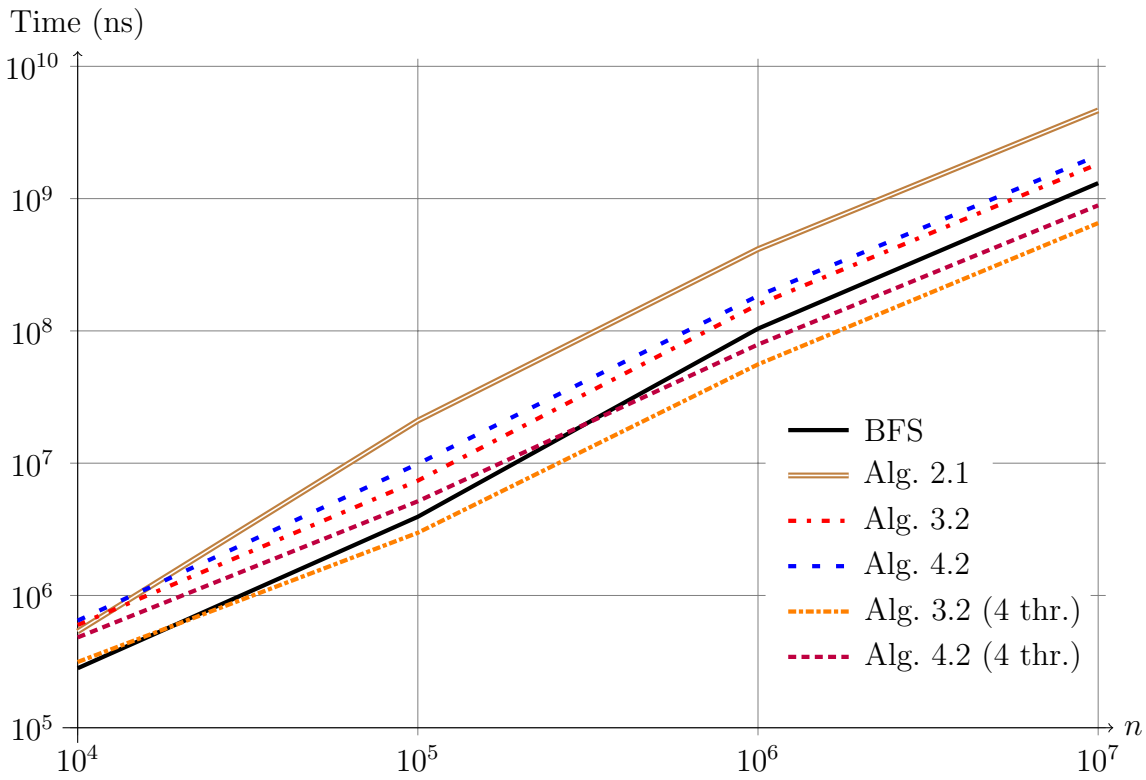



Figure 11: Average time per plane triangulation on a uniform random sample.

# 5 Experimental Performance and Parallelism

A C implementation of each algorithm is available [3]. For each $i$ from $4 \ldots 7$, a uniform random sample of 100 plane triangulations of order $10^i$ was generated using the method of Poulalhon and Schaeffer [10]. Each algorithm, as well as a baseline $\mathcal{O}(n)$ breadth-first search (BFS), was run on each graph in the sample set; see Figure 11.

In Algorithm 3.2 and Algorithm 4.2, it is possible to maintain a stack of independent recursive frames, and to have a pool of threads execute them concurrently. The amount of parallelism possible using this method greatly varies depending on the graph structure, but a 2-3x average performance gain (2.8x for Alg. 3.2, and 2.4x for Alg. 4.2) was observed when using 4 threads to path color large random triangulations, see Figure 11.

Our parallel implementation of Algorithm 3.2 maintains a shared lock-guarded stack which all threads may push/pop recursive frames to/from.

Algorithm 4.2 is trickier to adapt to parallel execution: the pairs of recursive calls in Case 3.2 rely on a sequential execution order. If we save a local copy of $S(v), A(v), B(v)$ for each $v \in \{x, y, z\}$ alongside each frame, then the recursive calls in Case 3.2.1 with $u_2 = x$, Case 3.2.2, Case 3.2.3.1, and Case 3.2.3.2 with $u_2 = y$ become order independent. However, in Case 3.2.1 with $u_2 \neq x$, and Case 3.2.3.2 with $u_2 \neq y$, the second call will always depend on the color of $u_2$ (the remaining color in $L(u_2)$) computed by the first.

Our parallel implementation of Algorithm 4.2 maintains a shared object pool of frames and a shared stack of references to frames in the pool. Frames are added to the pool in the usual course of the algorithm, but only pushed to the stack if they are ready to execute. For each $v \in G$, we store an optional reference to a frame that will become ready when $v$ has been colored. To allow for multiple frames to await the coloring of one vertex, each frame in the pool stores an optional reference to a "next frame in line" (i.e. an "intrusive" linked list). When a vertex $v$ is colored, each frame waiting on $v$ is pushed to the stack.

# References


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